

Food Benefit Issuance

Policy: WIC staff prescribes monthly supplemental foods in quantities that do not exceed the regulatory maximums and are appropriate for the participant's age, category, profile, and nutritional needs.

Regulation: 7 CFR 246.10

Procedure/Additional Guidance:

WIC staff assign food packages based on the participant's age, category, profile, and nutrition risk factors. Staff may choose a model food package which contains specific combinations of foods that are most frequently issued to participants. From the Food Package panel, staff members have the ability to:

- Assign one of the displayed model food packages -OR-
- Select a model and then tailor it -OR-
- Create a new food package.

The selected food package remains in effect until the user selects a different food package. In order to change a food package, the user must enter a new effective date. The food package effective date is the date the food package is first available for issuance. In Compass, the food package effective date defaults to today's date. Compass functionality allows the user to set a future food package effective date. When selecting a new food package for the following month, make the effective date the first day of the following month. For example, on July 15 if a new food package will be needed for August, use the date selector to make the effective date of the new food package August 1. For benefits issued and then exchanged on the same day, the new food package effective date will be the same date as the previous effective date.

Note: Non-formula food packages may only be changed in the current month if none of the food items have been redeemed.

Issuance Cycle

The majority of WIC participants are issued food benefits for three months at a time.

Automatic Food Package Update for Infants

Compass automatically changes model food packages for infants at **4 months** of age. When that happens, the word "Changed" is added to the name of the updated food package. Tailored food packages do not automatically update at milestones. WIC staff need to reassess at milestones and create new tailored packages if needed. WIC staff have the ability to over-ride the automatic changes. When a participant's category and age change, Compass displays new model food packages meeting the participant's profile that can be assigned. Changing risk factors may prompt the need to change food packages. If a food package is inappropriate for a participant's age or category, or contains more than the maximum allotment of foods, Compass will not verify the package. Staff must correct the package before issuing food benefits.

Food Package Tailoring

Nutrition tailoring is the process of modifying an individual food package to better meet the supplemental nutritional needs of each participant. It entails making substitutions, reductions, and/or eliminations to food types and physical food forms to accommodate special dietary needs, cultural practices, and/or personal preference. Offering a participant substitution is the first step before eliminating or reducing foods. Individual nutrition tailoring is allowed based on the WIC staff's assessment of a participant's supplemental nutrition needs. By federal regulation, the full maximum monthly allowance of all supplemental foods in all food packages must be made available to participants if medically or nutritionally warranted. The one exception is that breastfed infants who also receive supplemental formula should be provided the minimum amount of supplemental formula and offered counseling and support to ensure breastfeeding success. Tailoring the package to provide less than the full amount is appropriate only when:

- ✓ Medically or nutritionally warranted such as removing an item due to a food allergy
- ✓ A participant refuses or cannot use the maximum monthly amount

- ✓ Quantities necessary to supplement another program's contribution to fill a medical prescription are less than the maximum monthly amount.

There are instances when issuance of a food package requires both medical documentation from a health care provider licensed to prescribe in Colorado and approval by the WIC High Risk Counselor.

Documentation of Food Package Tailoring

All substitutions are considered for client preference unless stated otherwise. If the reason for substitution was not simply client preference, the reason why a substitution was issued must be expressly documented. Documentation is critical so that all staff providing follow up can readily see that a specific tailored food package was purposefully assigned.

Guidelines for Issuing Homeless Food Packages

The WIC food package may be tailored to accommodate the unique needs and circumstances of homeless participants. Some of these adaptations may be necessary because of their living circumstances. Information regarding storage, transportation, ability to access the grocery store, and use of specific food items should be obtained when certifying the participant. If the person is residing in a shelter, the WIC food package must be kept separate from the general inventories and be used by the participant only. Below is a list of ways a food package may be tailored to meet the needs of homeless individuals:

- If proper refrigeration is not available, eggs and fluid milk, including evaporated, may not be issued to the participant. UHT or powdered milk should be issued instead. The participant should be instructed to mix one glass of milk at a time. Nonfat dry milk should not be used for children between 12-24 months of age.
- Hardboiled eggs should be issued instead of raw eggs if cooking facilities are not available but refrigeration is available. If neither refrigeration or cooking facilities are available, one 18-ounce jar of peanut butter may be substituted for 1 dozen eggs.
- Participants may be issued single serving containers of juice. If single serving containers of juice will not provide the maximum allowable ounces, participants should be counseled on this and offered the choice of whether they want to receive the 64 oz. container instead.
- Breastfeeding should be encouraged as the easiest and safest way to feed the infant. Formula-fed infants should receive powder formula, mixed one bottle at a time. Ready-to feed formula may be issued according to Colorado WIC Food Package Tailoring Guidelines. No exemptions or exceptions are allowed from the requirement for medical documentation to support the issuance of exempt infant formulas and WIC-eligible medical foods.
- Local agency WIC staff determine whether to provide monthly or tri-monthly food benefits. Factors to consider when determining food benefit issuance include: length of time the individual plans to stay in the area, length of time it is possible to stay in the shelter, nutritional risk factors, and access to transportation.



Homeless Food Package Guidelines

WIC Food	Refrigeration, dry storage, and cooking	<u>NO</u> refrigeration and <u>NO</u> cooking facilities with dry storage
Milk	Same as regular food package whereby participant may choose to purchase fluid milk in quarts, half-gallons or gallons-or- powdered or evaporated milk	Powder or UHT
Cheese	Substitute for milk -same as regular food package	Substitute for milk-same as regular food package
Eggs	Same as regular food package Or can issued boiled eggs if refrigeration is available but cooking facilities are not	Substitute peanut butter
Juice	Same as regular package -or- issue single serving juice	Same as regular package - or- issue single serving juice
Breakfast cereal & infant cereal	Same as regular package	Same as regular package
Whole grains	Same as regular package	Same as regular package
Peanut butter and Beans	Same as regular package whereby participant has a choice of peanut butter, dry or canned beans	Encourage purchase of peanut butter or canned beans
Canned fish	Same as regular package	Encourage purchase of single serving size cans
Fruit & Vegetable voucher	Same as regular package	Encourage purchase of items that do not require cooking or refrigeration such as apples, oranges, carrots, etc.
Formula	Powder <u>or</u> liquid conc. or ready-to-feed	Powder

For more information regarding certification of and providing services for homeless participants, see the *Homeless Applicants* policy in Section 8, *Certification, Eligibility and Coordination*

Hospitalized or Institutionalized Participants

If a participant is in the hospital, long term care facility or an institution, a WIC food package cannot be provided until discharged, since the institution is responsible for feeding the patient.

Issuance of WIC food benefits

WIC benefits may be issued remotely for all remote appointment types. A verbal acknowledgement of the food benefit issuance suffices since a signature cannot be captured on the signature pad. If the client is present in the clinic, benefits should be issued in the clinic and a signature must be captured on the signature pad.

Food Package Sizes

Most foods are available in a variety of sizes at local retailers and on the Colorado WIC Food List and Shopping Guide. It is allowed for participants to choose to purchase sizes that will provide less than the maximum allowable amounts per their preference. However, WIC staff must provide education on how to reach the maximum allowable amounts, and ensure participants are aware that picking other sizes may result in losing benefits.



Food Benefit Signature & proof of ID capture

The endorser/participant/proxy shows proof of ID and electronically signs the signature pad to acknowledge receipt of food benefits. Staff records the proof of ID seen in the Proof of Identification drop down on the Signature Capture pop up in Compass.

No Signature Available

If a signature is not available, staff must check the *No Signature Available* checkbox and select one of the following reasons:

- Remote Appointment - Verbal Acknowledgement.
- Equipment malfunction.
- Mailed.
- Refused.
- NE Class.
- Other (If selected, the reason must be documented in the participant's file).

There are two ways to capture an electronic signature from those attending a NE class:

- Signature can be captured at the time benefits are issued.
- If benefits are issued while the participant is in the NE class, staff can capture the participant signature after the class by accessing the NE Class in *Scheduler* and clicking on the *Signature* button.

SUMMARY OF COLORADO WIC FOOD PACKAGES

Food Category	Infant 0-3 mo	Infant 4-5 mo	Infant 6-11 mo	Excl BF ^a Infant 6-11 mo	Child 1 year	Child 2-4 yr	Pregnant	Partially BF (In Range)	Postpartum/ Novel BF Woman	Excl BF Woman ^b	Excl BF Multiples
Infant Formula ^c	870 oz pwd 806 oz conc -or- 832 oz RTF	960 oz pwd 884 oz conc -or- 913 oz RTF	696 oz pwd 624 oz conc -or- 643 oz RTF								
Infant Cereal			1, 8-oz boxes	2, 8-oz boxes							
Baby Food Fruit/Veg.			32 4-oz jars -or- 16 (4-oz) jars FV + \$11CVB -or- 0 (4-oz) jars + \$22 CVB	32 4-oz jars -or- 16 (4-oz) jars FV + \$11CVB -or- 0 (4-oz) jars + \$22 CVB							
Baby Food Meat				16 2.5-oz jars							
Milk ^{d, e, f}					12qt. whole	14 qt. 1%/fat free	16 qt. 1%/fat free	16 qt. 1%/fat free	16 qt. 1%/fat free	16 qt. 1%/fat free	24 qt. 1%/fat free
Cheese ^g					1 lb may replace 3 qt. milk	1 lb may replace 3 qt. milk	1 lb may replace 3 qt. milk	1 lb may replace 3 qt. milk	1 lb may replace 3 qt. milk	2 lb may replace 6 qt. milk	3 lb may replace 9 qt. milk
Eggs ^h					1 dozen	1 dozen	1 dozen	1 dozen	1 dozen	2 dozen	3 dozen
Juice ⁱ					1 64-oz container	1 64-oz container	1 64-oz container	1 64-oz container	1 64-oz container	1 64 oz container	1 64 oz container even, 2 64 oz containers odd ^j
Breakfast Cereal					36 oz	36 oz	36 oz	36 oz	36 oz	36 oz	54 oz
Whole Grains					24 oz	24 oz	48 oz	48 oz	48 oz.	48 oz	72 oz
Dry Beans and/or Peanut Butter ^{k, l}					1 lb beans or 18 oz peanut butter	1 lb beans or 18 oz peanut butter	1 lb beans and 18 oz peanut butter	1 lb beans and 18 oz peanut butter	1 lb beans or 18 oz peanutbutter	1 lb beans and 18 oz peanut butter	1.5 lbs dry beans, or 96 oz. canned beans and 27 oz peanut butter
CVB F/V					\$26.00	\$26.00	\$47.00	\$52.00	\$47.00	\$52.00	\$78.00
Canned Fish					6 oz.	6 oz.	10 oz.	15 oz.	10 oz.	20 oz.	30 oz.

^a Exclusively BF infants 0-6 months are counted as WIC participants even though they are not issued food benefits.

^b Exclusively BF woman's package also issued to women partially (mostly or "in range") breastfeeding multiples from the same pregnancy, and pregnant women who are partially (mostly) breastfeeding singleton infants.

^c Reconstituted ounces of infant formula. Formula amounts are considered "up to" amounts. Colorado WIC uses the Full Nutrition Benefit (FNB) for concentrate formula and the Maximum Monthly Allowance for powder and RTF formulas.

^d **Plant-based milk alternatives** milk may be substituted for cow's milk at the rate of 1 quart of **plant-based milk alternative** per 1 quart cow's milk. Following a nutrition assessment, plant-based **milk alternatives** may be substituted for milk in situations that include but are not limited to milk allergy, lactose intolerance, vegan diet, religious preference, or participant preference.

^e Tofu may be substituted for cow's milk at the rate of 1 lb tofu per 1 quart milk Following a nutrition assessment, **tofu** may be substituted for milk in situations that include but are not limited to milk allergy, lactose intolerance, vegan diet, religious preference, or participant preference.

^f Yogurt may be substituted for fluid milk at the rate of 1 quart yogurt per 1 quart milk. A maximum of 2 quarts of milk may be substituted. Additional amounts of yogurt are not authorized. Whole yogurt or low fat yogurt is the standard yogurt for issuance to 1-year-old children (12 through 23 months.) Non-fat yogurt may be issued to 1-year-old children for whom overweight and obesity are a concern. Low-fat or nonfat yogurts are the only types of yogurt authorized for children ≥ 24 months of age and women.

^g Maximum substitution of milk for cheese:

Children: 3 quarts (maximum 1 pound cheese)

Pregnant, Postpartum and Partially (Mostly) BF Women: 3 quarts (maximum 1 pound cheese)

Exclusively BF Women: 6 quarts (maximum 2 lb cheese).

Women Exclusively BF Multiples: 9 quarts (maximum 3 lb cheese)

^h Beans or peanut butter can be substituted for eggs at the rate of 1 unit beans/peanut butter per 1 dozen eggs (1 unit = 1 lb dry beans, 18 oz peanut butter, or 64 ounces canned beans. This substitution is allowed in situations that include but are not limited to egg allergy, vegan diet, religious preference, or participant preference.

ⁱ A \$3 CVB can be substituted for 64 oz. of juice.

^j Foods can be divided into “even” and “odd” month packages to provide the full authorized amount of juice over a 2-month period.

^k A combination of dry beans, canned beans, and peanut butter may be issued in order to provide the full authorization of beans and peanut butter.

^l Following a nutrition assessment, alternative nut and seed butters can be offered in place of peanut butter in situations that include but are not limited to peanut allergy or participant preference.

Additional Allowed Substitutions:

- Canned evaporated milk may be substituted for fresh at the rate of one 12-oz can per quart fresh milk.
- Powdered milk may be substituted for fresh at an equal reconstituted rate.
- Infant cereal (32 oz) may be substituted for 36 oz breakfast cereal for women and children receiving WIC eligible nutritionals (formulas).
- Jarred infant fruits and vegetables may be substituted for CVB for women and children receiving WIC eligible nutritionals (formulas). The rate of exchange is 6.25 oz infant fruits and vegetables for every \$1 CVB.

Standard milk types:

- Whole milk is the standard milk for one-year-old children (12-23 months).
- Low fat (1%) or fat free milk is the standard milk for women and 2-4-year-old children (24-59 months)

Issuing milk for overweight one-year old children

Based on the WIC CWA's determination (through individual nutritional assessment and consultation with the child's health care provider if necessary) fat reduced milks (2%, 1% or fat free) may be issued to one-year-old children for whom obesity and overweight are a concern who meet these criteria:

- Overweight: Child's weight for length is at or above the 98th percentile.
- Rapid weight gain: A child whose weight for length, initially at or above the 50th percentile crossed two percentile curves. For example, a child going from the 50th to the 90th percentile, or going from the 75th to the 95th percentile

Issuing milk for underweight women and 2-4-year-old children

Based on the WIC High Risk Counselor determination (through individual nutritional assessment and consultation with the participant's health care provider if necessary) whole or 2 % milk may be issued to women with insufficient weight gain and underweight 2-4-year-old children (24-59 months) only when participant is also receiving a special formula.